MILIND SHELTE



NEW WAVE? Ajit Pawar with rebel leaders, Jul. 5

MAHAGAME AT PLAY

Ajit Pawar's faction gives the BJP more leverage to rule the state and damage the MVA, but they must be wary of the Maratha manoos

PLUSES

- The NCP dissidents not only shore up numbers for the ruling alliance, but also put Shinde and his men on the defensive, showing them they are not indispensable
- The NCP break-up may weaken the Maharashtra Vikas Aghadi (MVA), and also the efforts to build national opposition unity in which Sharad Pawar had emerged as a fulcrum
- The BJP's 2024 Lok Sabha prospects in the state get a boost with Ajit Pawar's faction having a greater grassroots connection than Shinde's Shiv Sena, especially in west and north Maharashtra
- With the BJP netting two major factions of the NCP and Sena, it has mustered a formidable alliance that could help it win a majority both in the Lok Sabha and assembly polls in 2024

MINUSES

- Shinde's men may feel sidelined as coveted posts go elsewhere, which may lead to some returning to the Uddhav faction of Sena
- Attacks on Pawar Sr could lead to the cadre and loyalists coalescing around him
- The NCP is dominated by the Marathas, any split induced by the BJP may trigger a backlash, especially as the BJP national leadership is seen to be Gujarati and, in Maharashtra, led by a Brahmin (Devendra Fadnavis)
- A perception exists that Shinde's BJP-engineered defection has led to sympathy among the masses for the Uddhav-led Sena faction. The NCP split, along with the image that the BJP is misusing the ED, could boost this sentiment

SHINDE'S PREDICAMENT

However, the elephant in the room is the predicament that the CM finds himself in. Ajit and his men will reduce the BJP's dependence on Shinde, whose camp was flexing its muscles with front-page advertisements in newspapers claiming the CM was more popular than Fadnavis. Shinde was also seeking an equal share in power and was resisting demands from the BJP to give marching orders to five of the nine Sena ministers.

Ex-CM and senior Congress leader Prithviraj Chavan has claimed that the BJP has promised Ajit the CM's post, and that Shinde and his men may get disqualified as legislators. Petitions seeking the disqualification of 54 Shiv Sena MLAs, both from the Shinde and Thackeray camps, have been filed before assembly speaker Rahul Narwekar. The Thackeray faction has also targeted two independents and an MLA of the Prahar Janashakti Party, who switched from their camp to Shinde's. In May, the Supreme Court had ruled that the speaker must consider the party constitution as well as any other rules which specify the structure of the leadership in arriving at a decision. This means he will have to determine who constitutes the 'real' Shiv Sena whose whip applies to the MLAs. Narwekar's ruling will also have a bearing on the petitions filed by the rival NCP camps.

Ajit loyalist and MLC Amol Mitkari has, meanwhile, stirred the pot by insisting that his boss is CM material. The latter, too, declared his ambitions for the post on July 5. (For what it's worth, Fadnavis and Union minister Narayan Rane have reiterated that the alliance will contest the elections in 2024 under Shinde's leadership.)

Incidentally, among the excuses that Shinde and his men had given for breaking ranks with the MVA was Ajit's overbearing style. They claimed that the latter, who was deputy CM and finance minister in the MVA regime, was partial towards the NCP when it came to the distribution of funds. Already, Shinde's ministers are up in arms over the possibility that Ajit and his men may get plum portfolios like finance. In a loaded statement, Shinde confidant and excise minister Shambhuraj Desai has said that in case former boss Uddhav Thackeray sends feelers, they may well respond to them.

"These developments are a setback to both Ajit Pawar and Shinde. The state cabinet expansion was pending for a year, but the hopes of Shinde's men for cabinet berths are now up in smoke. It's doubtful whether another round of expansion will happen...," says journalist and political analyst Vijay Chormare. After the swearing-in, Shinde tried to see the positives, maintaining that the new ally will make his dispensation a "triple engine" government. But as the adage goes, two is company. Three could definitely become a crowd. ■

with Anilesh S. Mahajan